

Skunks

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Mammalia
ORDER	Carnivora
FAMILY	Mephitidae
SPECIES	12

Skunks—and the Asian stink badgers—form a group of mammals with an infamous armament of chemical defense. Skunks have not only a more potent repellent than the mustelids, but also the means to fire it at an attacker.

Anatomy

Skunks are ground-dwelling omnivores with a muscular build and strong claws for digging for roots and grubs. They have particularly well-developed anal scent glands armed with muscles, which enable them to squirt foul-smelling sulphurous fluid when threatened or molested. This can repel the largest of predators and a direct facial hit can cause blindness or asphyxiation. Their strikingly black and

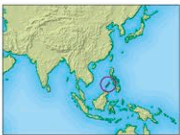
white pattern serves as a warning of this behavior, and skunks may do “handstands,” flashing the tail as a prelude to attack.

Opportunists

Skunks prefer open wooded areas and avoid dense forest. They are mostly active at night or dusk, when they feed on vegetation, fruit, insects, and small vertebrates; certain species may be resistant to snake venom. In some places they raid domestic refuse in the manner of raccoons. They lead solitary lives but some species may gather in communal dens—especially in winter.

Mydaus marchei

Palawan stink badger



Length	12½–19½ in (32–49 cm)
Tail	½–1¼ in (1.5–4.5 cm)
Weight	1¼–5½ lb (0.8–2.5 kg)
Social unit	Individual
Status	Least concern

Location Philippines (Palawan and Busuanga islands)



Slow and ponderous, when attacked the Palawan stink badger accurately squirts an extremely noxious fluid from its anal glands over a distance of ¾ ft (1 m). It has a short tail, small ears and eyes, a typically badgerlike, stocky body, and a long, flexible, almost hairless snout for rooting out small soil dwellers such as worms, grubs, and slugs. The fur is dark brown with a yellow head cap that tapers to a stripe between the shoulders. The stink badger lives alone in a rocky den or old porcupine burrow.



TRANSPORTING OFFSPRING
Young striped skunks are carried from place to place in their mother's mouth. This youngster may have wandered off or is simply being moved to another den.

MAMMALS

Conepatus humboldtii

Humboldt's hog-nosed skunk



Length	8–12½ in (20–32 cm)
Tail	6½–8 in (16.5–20.2 cm)
Weight	1–5½ lb (0.5–2.5 kg)
Social unit	Individual
Status	Least concern

Location S. South America



Along with the typical small skunk head, stocky body, and fluffy tail, the Humboldt's hog-nosed skunk also has a broad nose pad for rooting up food. Its fur is black or reddish brown with a white stripe along each side; the stripes meet on the head and extend onto the tail. It will feed on virtually anything edible, but mainly eats insects. Like other skunks, it occupies a secure den under a rock, in a burrow, or among bushes, and it can spray enemies with foul-smelling fluid.



Spilogale putorius

Eastern spotted skunk



Length	7½–13 in (19–33 cm)
Tail	3¼–11 in (8–28 cm)
Weight	7–31 oz (207–885 g)
Social unit	Individual
Status	Vulnerable

Location E. to C. USA, N.E. Mexico



Heavy-bodied and short-legged, this skunk relies on striking coloration to warn its enemies of the noxious fluid sprayed from its anal glands. The white markings on the body differ in every individual; there is usually, however, a white patch on the forehead and a white tail tip. Food includes a variety of small animals, fruit, and vegetable matter. Generally solitary, up to 8 eastern spotted skunks may share a den in winter.

Mephitis mephitis

Striped skunk



Length	6½–16 in (17–40 cm)
Tail	6–18½ in (15–47 cm)
Weight	1¼–9 lb (0.6–4.1 kg)
Social unit	Individual
Status	Least concern

Location C. Canada to N. Mexico

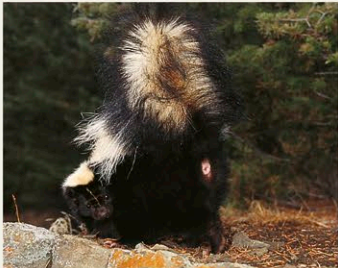


As with other skunks, the striped skunk has black-and-white warning coloration. Its diet includes insects, small mammals, birds and their eggs, fish, mollusks, fruit, seeds, and human leftover food. It is solitary but may gather in communal winter dens among rocks, in old burrows, or under outbuildings. The 5–7 young may stay with their mother for more than a year.



COLORATION
This skunk is black with a thin, white stripe on the muzzle, and wider, upper-back stripes from head to tail.

NOXIOUS DEFENSE



If threatened, the striped skunk fluffs its fur, arches its back, and lifts its tail. Should the aggressor remain, it stands on its front feet, rear feet in the air, and twists its body. It then ejects a foul-smelling liquid over its head for up to 9¼ ft (3m), from 2 nozzle-like ducts protruding from its anus.